

CIVIL RIGHTS LEADER (1918–)

NELSON MANDELA

Nelson Rolihlahla Mandela was born in the Eastern Cape, South Africa. He served a 27-year prison sentence for his part in antiapartheid activities. Released from prison in 1990, he became South Africa's first black president in 1994. Mandela has unrivaled global status as a pioneer for peace and democracy.

“Never, never, and never again shall it be that this beautiful land will again experience the oppression of one by another...”

NELSON MANDELA, INAUGURAL ADDRESS, MAY 9, 1994



Dr. Hendrik Verwoerd, Prime Minister of South Africa from 1958 to 1966, created a system of apartheid (see right), which embodied his “white supremacist” belief that not all races were equal. His views echoed Adolf Hitler’s philosophy of the Aryan master race (see pp.400–01). The extreme inequalities created in South African society under apartheid raised voices of protest not only among blacks, “coloreds,” and sections of South Africa’s white population, but also internationally.

The struggle

In 1960, 69 people died and 180 were injured when police turned their guns on a nonviolent demonstration organized by the antiapartheid group Pan Africanist Congress (PAC). This massacre in the township of Sharpeville

triggered a shift to more militant tactics among activists. In 1961, Nelson Mandela became leader of the military wing of the African National Congress (ANC) political party, beginning a campaign of sabotage targeting government installations. Mandela and other members of the ANC were arrested in 1962 and subsequently sentenced to life imprisonment. At his trial, Mandela spoke of freedom, democracy, and equality for all South Africans. His long imprisonment became a subject of growing international condemnation.

The “Homeland System,” introduced in the 1960s, aimed to complete the implementation of apartheid by creating



Steve Biko

This 1977 cover of *Drum*, a South African magazine for black issues and culture, features antiapartheid activist Steve Biko. Biko died as a result of beatings sustained in police custody in 1977.

independent homelands where blacks were forced to live. These areas were impoverished rural areas with no real capacity to function as separate states. The relocation of blacks to the homelands

13 PERCENT of the country was divided into 10 homelands.
80 PERCENT of the population lived in these homelands.

meant that they were no longer South African and worked in the country as foreign migrants without citizens’ rights.

Apartheid and Beyond

Apartheid was a brutal system that imposed the will of a minority on the majority of the South African population. When it ended in the 1990s, there followed an extraordinary attempt to come to terms with the past, as South Africans of all races cooperated in a process known as “Truth and Reconciliation.”



BEFORE

South Africa’s ruling powers maintained a divided population for much of 20th century.

THE PRE-APARTHEID ERA

Between 1910 and 1948, the South African Government pursued measures to deprive blacks and “coloreds” (those of mixed racial origins) of the right to vote or to own land. Acts such as the **Native Urban Areas Act** of 1923 resulted in “surplus” blacks being removed from cities, creating many “whites-only” areas.

THE NATIONAL PARTY

In 1948 the uncompromisingly racist **National Party** rose to power in South Africa and adopted a policy of “apartheid”

(see right), a legal system that completely segregated (separated) the political, social, and cultural lives of white and black South Africans.

APARTHEID LAW

Early apartheid measures included “blood laws,” such as the Immorality Act and Population Registration Act (1950), which banned intermarriage and sexual relations between races. Public transportation and amenities were divided into **separate areas for whites and blacks**, and segregation of the education system and employment ensured that blacks had no prospects other than menial low-paid work.



OFFICIAL SEGREGATION